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PHI101 Introduction to Philosophy
9 June 2026

What It Means to be a Good Citizen Under a Free and Fair State

I.) Introduction

At the core of a democratic society is freedom – both the promise of it, and the prerequisite for its undoing. In effect, a state which guarantees individual liberties **must** depend on individuals who, of their own accord, choose to uphold and sustain democratic values and principles. This could be considered a political dilemma, but the difficulties run deeper than that – this is a crisis of individual responsibility and civic virtue. Consider this: if the legitimacy and efficacy of a free and fair state rests on the consent and participation of its citizens, then what does citizenship **actually demand** of the individual? And what happens if those demands are not met?

This essay will explore that problem precisely: the decay of public trust, civic virtue, and democratic values in the modern Western political sphere, through the lens of the individual citizen. The core of this argument is that a truly free and fair state is not simply one that protects individual rights, but is also sustained by citizens who recognize their political obligation to the commonwealth, and who exercise their rights regularly. When this civic foundation erodes, democracy does not collapse due to external forces or economic upheaval, but rots from within.

II.) The Social Contract and Our Obligation to the Law

In 1689, just shy of 90 years until 1776, John Locke would publish his *Second Treatise of Government* anonymously. This would be one of the principal documents upon which the ideals of modern Western democracy would be built, while additionally expanding on the established concept of social contract theory. Prior to Locke, another English philosopher by the name of Thomas Hobbes had written his own work, *Leviathan* (or *The Matter, Forme and Power of a Commonwealth Ecclesiasticall and Civil*) during the English Civil War of the mid 17th century. Hobbes argued that the state of nature is chaotic and that, indeed, human life itself is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short" (Hobbes, *Leviathan*, pt. 1, chpt. 13) and that the only way to ensure the safety and security of the people was for them to submit completely to the authority of an absolute sovereign.

In Locke's *First Treatise of Government*, he spends most of the treatise deconstructing and critiquing the arguments of another pro-monarchist contemporary, Sir Robert Filmer. During the *Second Treatise of Government*, Locke presents his own case for governance, developing foundational political ideas which our own Founding Fathers would consider during the American Revolution. As opposed to Hobbes and his pessimistic outlook on nature and human life, Locke proposes that men are "all free, equal, and independent" and that "no one can be put out of this estate, and subjected to the political power of another, without his own consent" (Locke, *Second Treatise*, chpt. 8, sect. 95). This (and many of Locke's words) are a direct precursor to our own Declaration of Independence's "life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness", a statement which echoes Locke's core philosophy on natural rights; that we, as humans, possess inalienable rights which the government is made to protect, alongside the physical safety and security of its people. Furthermore, Locke establishes that, under a democracy, there is not only

the implicit agreement to the social contract (as with any civilized society) but also "an obligation, to every one of that society, to submit to the determination of the majority" (Locke, *Second Treatise*, chpt. 8, sect. 97).

Jean-Jacques Rousseau would further refine the concept of social contract theory in 1762 with his work, aptly titled, *The Social Contract*. Rousseau makes a critical observation early on in his writing regarding civic virtue under a democracy – that there is an everlasting tension between the private will of an individual, and the general will of the citizen body politic. Put plainly, this is Rousseau's warning about the citizen who "may wish to enjoy the rights of citizenship without being ready to fulfill the duties of a subject". Ultimately, he concludes that this sentiment "would destroy the body politic" (Rousseau, *Social Contract*, book 1, chpt. 7). While Hobbes asked why we need a government at all, and Locke asked what gives the government its legitimacy, Rousseau posits something a bit more disturbing: what happens when the citizens of a state just stop caring?

III.) Civic Virtue, Social Capital, and the Epistemology of Citizenship

In his 2024 article "America's Crisis of Civic Virtue" published in the *Journal of Democracy*, Arthur C. Brooks defines civic virtue as "the set of personal qualities associated with a civil or political order" and "a shared set of behavioral norms and basic moral rules that make the order's functioning possible" (Brooks, 2024, pg. 25). To further establish and set up his argument, Brooks also draws on Alexis de Tocqueville, a 19th century French diplomat and philosopher most known for his book *Democracy in America*, published circa 1835. Tocqueville, according to Brooks, recognized that no amount of law or force would be enough to sustain America's unique democracy; its survival depended on the willingness of citizens to conduct themselves with honesty and civility (Brooks, 2024, pg. 25). Even more startling than 17th – 19th century European thinkers making such assertions is that these are observations which some of the Founding Fathers themselves made (notably John Adams and James Madison), and the author of the article also mentions this, stating plainly in the very next paragraph that "the Founders doubted whether ordinary Americans possessed sufficient civic virtue for democratic self-government" (Brooks, 2024, pg. 25).

Brooks frames this not as a partisan issue, nor a problem of capitalism and its free markets, but as a sharp drop in public trust, honesty, and civility. An erosion and decay of shared values and principles, fueling distrust and incivility among citizens, only exacerbated by the modern media environment which seeds the sociopolitical landscape with misinformation, hyper-polarization, distrust, and partisan divide. This echoes Rousseau's concern that a republic cannot survive citizens who put private interest above the general will.

Many commentators have long criticized the modern media for rewarding outrage and bias, a problem compounded even more so by the rise and popularization of the

Internet, social media, etc. This is the supply, but what seems to be ignored in almost every discussion is the demand. Media outlets seek to profit like any other business, but what drives that profit? Either a genuine desire for prejudice and hostility, or ignorance as to the kind of systemic collapse that such sensationalist dogma causes. Outlets profit by giving audiences what they engage with, so the real question is what drives that engagement. Plausibly, it is some mix of appetite for conflict, force of habit, and limited awareness of how corrosive sensationalism becomes over time.

American academic Tom Nichols doesn't shy away from this observation however. In his book, *The Death of Expertise*, he shines a light on the current epistemic negligence of the average American citizen. He critiques the culture of rampant anti-intellectualism found in most institutions today as a "means of short-circuiting democracy" before adding that "a stable democracy in any culture relies on the public actually understanding the implications of its own choices" (Nichols, 2017, pg. 231). Moreover, echoing concerns voiced centuries earlier, Nichols gives credence to the very real notion that Americans "no longer understand democracy to mean a condition of political equality" continuing on that "Americans now think of democracy as a state of actual equality, in which every opinion is as good as any other on almost any subject under the sun" (Nichols, 2017, pg. 232). This is the "anti-Socrates"; the refusal to acknowledge the limits of one's own knowledge.

This has significant implications when considering what is necessary for the efficacy, function, and existence of a free and fair state. If both Brooks and Nichols are correct in their assertions, that civic virtue, engagement, and an informed body politic are required to support and maintain a democracy between a government and the people, then the social contract outlined by Locke and Rousseau is not

merely under attack. In practice, it is being neglected by the very citizens it depends on in order to be upheld.

So if the civic and epistemic foundations of democracy are crumbling, what obligation does the informed, responsible, engaged citizen have to act? And what form would that action even take, now that the institutions made to support democratic action have begun to fail as well?

IV.) The Duty to Dissent

It has been established thus far that there is a sociopolitical obligation and duty which every citizen owes to the state in the form of active engagement, civic virtue, and informed participation. These are not optional elements of a democracy; they are the responsibilities of every citizen comprising the body politic if a free and fair state is to be sustained and supported. This obligation runs both ways though. When the state itself acts unjustly or wrongfully, the good citizen's duty changes from compliance to resistance. Obedience under injustice is **not** good citizenship; it is complacency or complicity, the kind of self-serving, ignorant apathy that degrades civic virtue in the first place.

Martin Luther King Jr., being a victim of injustice himself, understood this fact all too well. While imprisoned in Birmingham during the 1963 American Civil Rights Movement, Dr. King wrote the "Letter From Birmingham Jail". In it he argues that principled disobedience is, in fact, the highest form of civic engagement there is by stating that breaking an unjust law with grace "is in reality expressing the highest respect for the law" (King, pg. 4). This is also famously where Dr. King takes aim at the "white moderate", a citizen who is vocal in opinion but complicit in action, continuing on to reiterate the points mentioned by Brooks and Nichols earlier in this essay; that non-participation and epistemic apathy are not neutral positions.

A familiar adage holds that evil triumphs when good people do nothing, and Dr. King puts it much more pointedly and succinctly: "We will have to repent in this generation not merely for the hateful words and actions of the bad people but for the appalling silence of the good people" (King, pg. 5). This supports all previous assertions regarding the true threats to democracy today: erosion of public trust, epistemic complacency, civic disengagement, and complicity.

V.) The "Good Citizen" and Conclusion

What emerges from this is a portrait of the "good citizen" which is far more demanding than simple obedience to the law. The good citizen, as described by the social contract theorists who built the framework of modern democracy, is not merely law-abiding, but is actively engaged. They are epistemically responsible, willing to examine their own assumptions and acknowledge the limits of their knowledge, rather than retreat into the comfortable certainty that Nichols and Socrates both warned against. And when the state fails to uphold its end of the social contract, the good citizen does not fall silent; they dissent, as King did, openly and with conviction, because the preservation of justice demands it.

This is not an easy standard to meet, and no society has ever met it perfectly. However, the alternative is a populace that is passive, uninformed, and indifferent to injustice, which is not a stable democracy. It is a democracy in name only, with no real substance. Freedom, as initially established in the introduction, is both the promise of a democratic society and the prerequisite for its undoing. So the question has never been whether citizens are free to disengage from their responsibilities. The question is what remains of the republic when they do.

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Further Reading

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